

Beyond the Numbers: The Power of Narrative vs. Data Driven Storytelling Among Gen Z Consumers in Barcelona

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- *Digital media has changed how brands communicate (TikTok, Instagram, YouTube)*
- *Gen Z is the most active social media generation and increasingly skeptical of advertising*
- *AI-generated content introduces new challenges to credibility*

Introduction ✨

Problem ✨

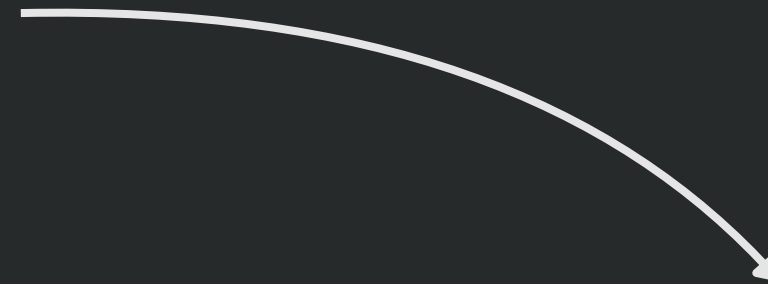
Gen Z is:

- *Highly exposed to digital advertising*
- *Emotionally driven*
- *Highly skeptical*
- *Frequently fact-checks brands*

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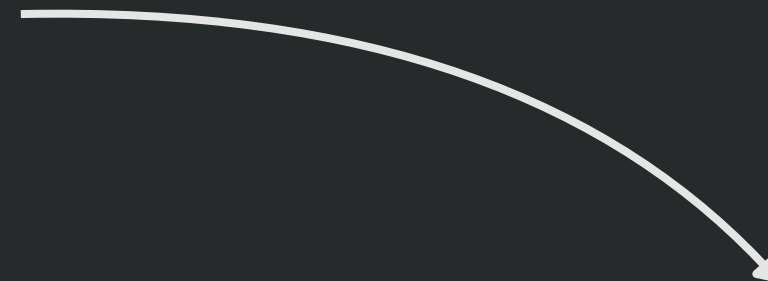
Research Gap ✨

Previous studies examined storytelling and statistics separately, but few have compared both approaches among Gen Z in digital advertising contexts.

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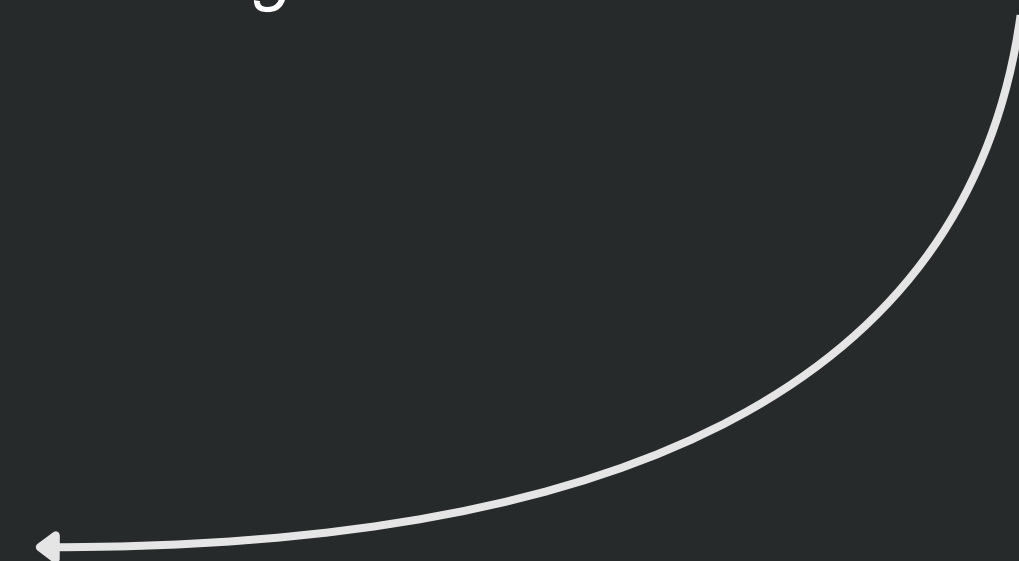


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✨*Research Question*

How does narrative-driven storytelling influence perceived brand authenticity and purchase intention compared with statistical communication among Gen Z consumers in Barcelona?



Objectives ✨

Primary Goal

To investigate and compare how narrative-driven data storytelling and purely statistical communication influence perceived brand authenticity and purchase intention among Gen Z consumers in Barcelona.

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Format Comparison



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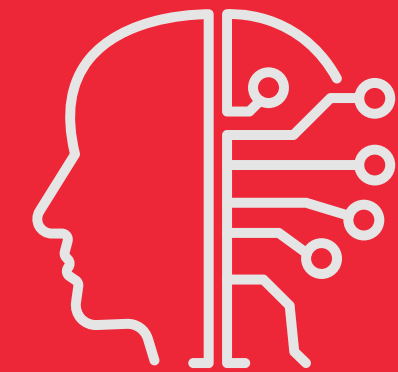
Narrative Impact



Statistical Impact



The "AI Factor"



Theoretical Framework ✨

Transportation Theory (Green & Brock, 2000)

Explains why storytelling creates:

- *immersion*
- *emotional engagement*
- *authenticity*

Elaboration Likelihood Model (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986)

Explains why:

- *statistics work when motivation is high (central route)*
- *consumers actively process evidence (peripheral route)*

These two frameworks are complementary, not competitive, each explaining different behavioral patterns depending on context

Methodology ✨

Mixed-method qualitative design combining two approaches

- Desk research
- Field research → Survey with A/B testing
→ Semi-structured in-depth interviews

Data was analyzed in Excel for the survey and transcripts for the interviews.

Example of first A/B test:



**The two images were created using AI*

Findings

Storytelling Creates Stronger Brand Connection

Survey Results

*72% remembered ads better when they told a story.
73% felt more connected when advertising was
personal and relatable.*

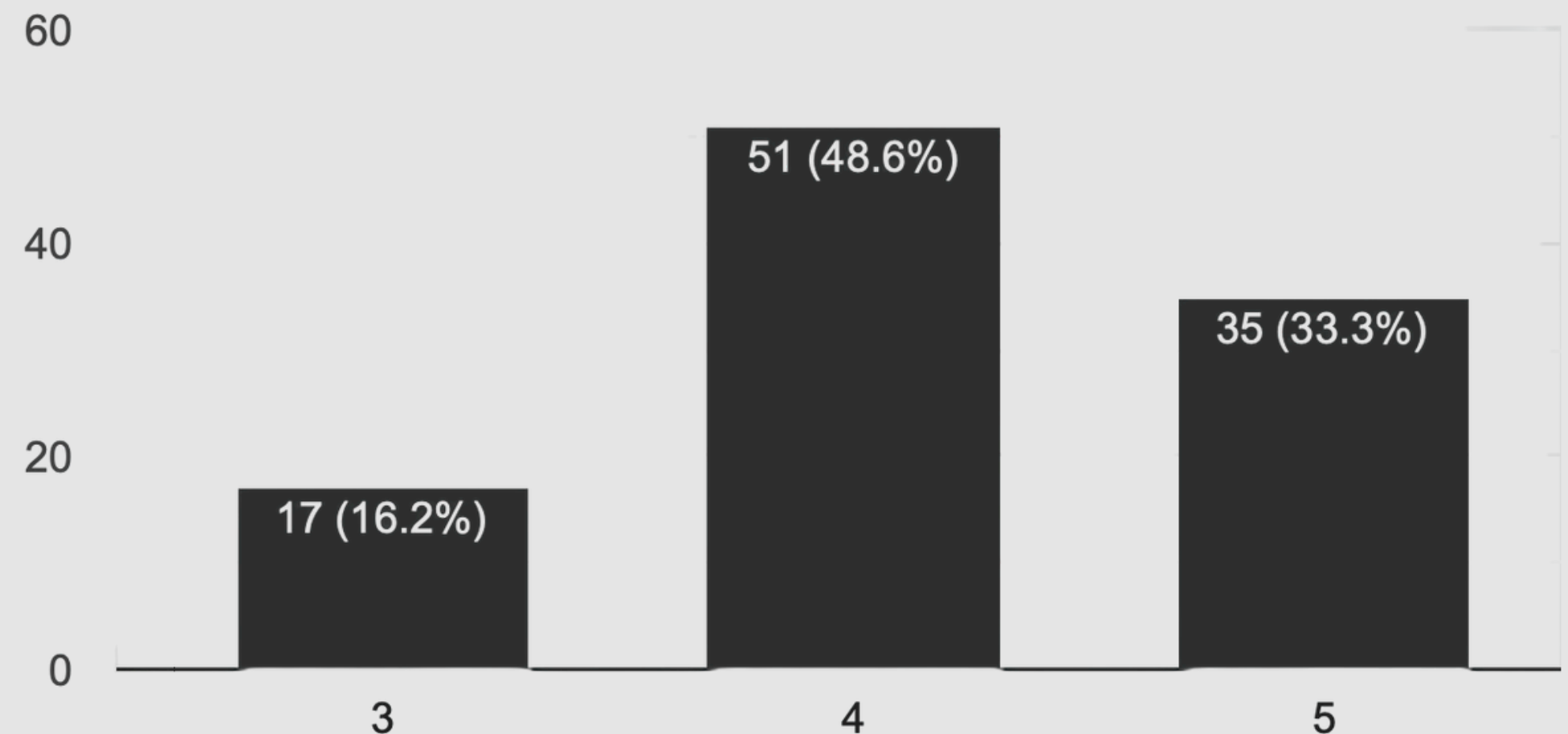
Interview Results

Participants repeatedly associated storytelling with:

- *authenticity*
- *emotional connection*
- *trust*

I feel more connected to a brand when their advertising feels personal and relatable.

105 responses



Findings

Statistics Matter in High-Stakes Decisions

Survey Results

Only 27% considered data an authenticity driver.

However:

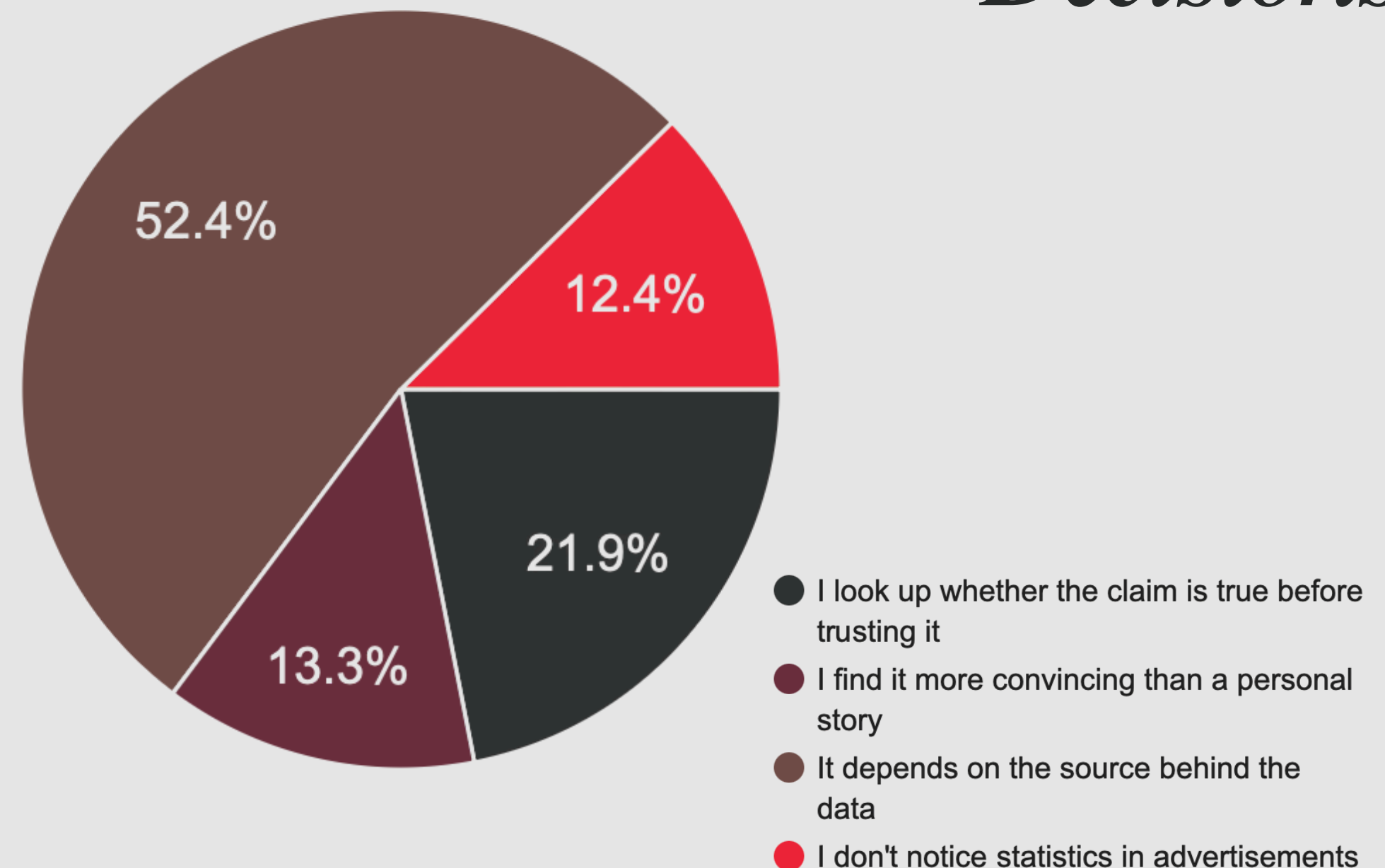
- *52.4% said statistical claims depend on the source.*
- *21.9% actively verify claims before trusting them.*

Interview Results

For:

- *health and lifestyle products*
- *expensive purchases*

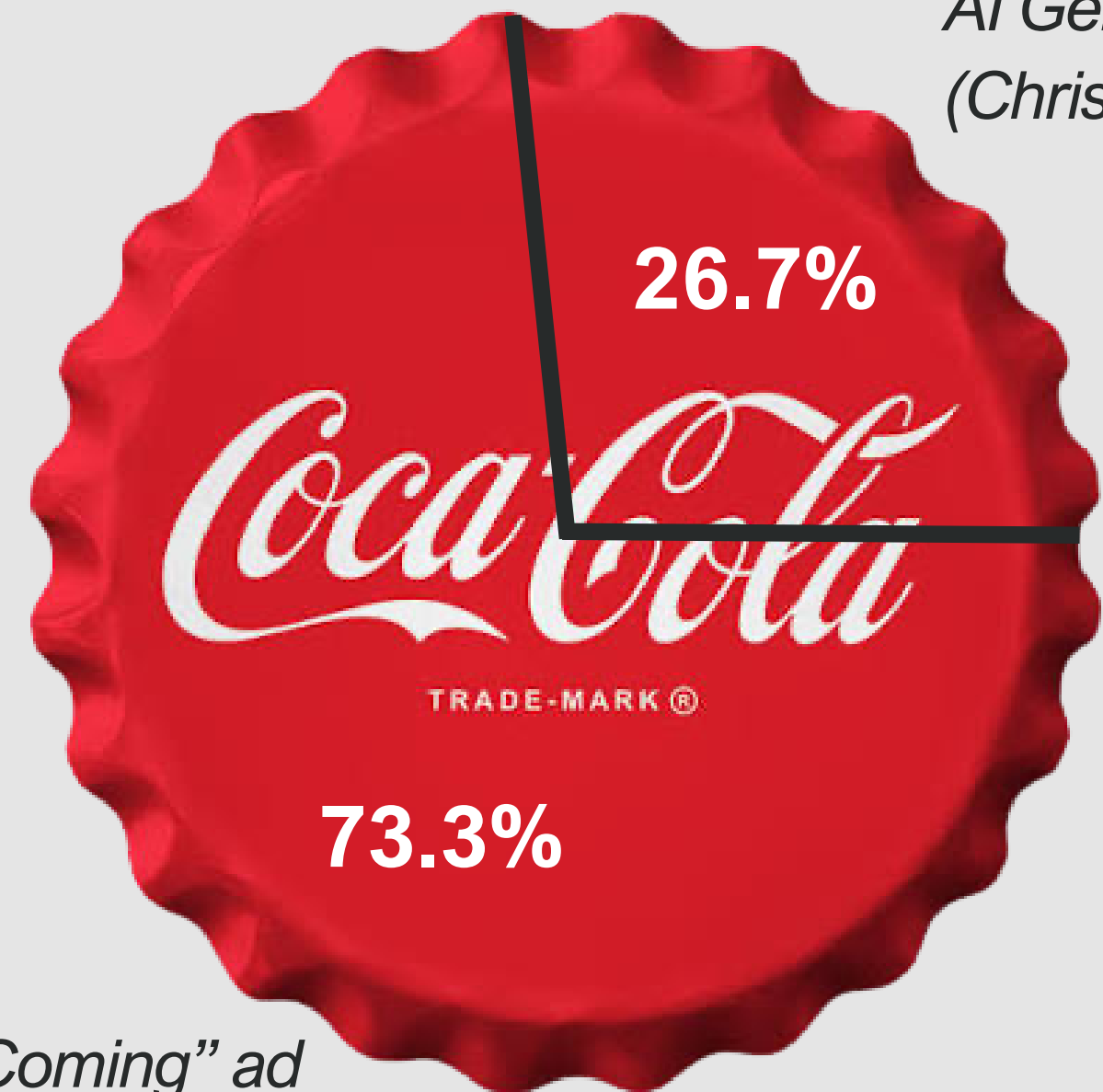
Participants wanted evidence and transparency.



Findings

AI Reduces Trust

*AI Generated ad
(Christmas 2025)*



*"Holidays are Coming" ad
(Christmas 2020)*

Survey Results

74% preferred the human-created Coca-Cola ad.

Respondents stated that AI ads:

- *feel fake*
- *look artificial*
- *reduce trust*

Interview Results

Participants accepted AI only when:

- *transparently disclosed*
- *combined with human creativity*
- *visually natural*

The Gen Z Paradox ✨

Gen Z wants both
Emotional Connection & Evidence-Based Trust

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Examples

→ 57% actively fact-check brand claims. → Storytelling drives engagement. → Statistics drive credibility.

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Main Discovery

Gen Z is simultaneously the most emotionally reachable and
the most critically skeptical consumer generation.

Conclusion

Final Answer to the Research Question

Narrative communication is more effective at creating brand authenticity and emotional engagement, while statistical communication becomes essential when consumers evaluate high-risk or high-involvement products.

The most effective strategy is not choosing one or the other, but combining both.

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Final Takeaway

"Gen Z wants stories that feel human and data they can trust."

¡Gracias!

